Other figures reinforce the grimness of the situation. The Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO), in its annual report for 2021-22, recorded contributions of 46.3 million members that year. The slide from the 48.9 million members in pre-pandemic year 2019-20 indicated a decline in jobs in the organised sector. "Evidently, formal sector employment measured through EPFO contributions had not recovered to its pre-pandemic levels till at least 2021-22. It had declined by 5.3 per cent," says Vyas.



"THE THRUST ON URBAN INFRA IN TIER 2 & 3 CITIES AND THE Rs 79,000 CR. PUSH TO HOUSING VIA PM AWAS YOJANA COULD CREATE A SIGNIFICANT NUMBER OF JOBS"

—NIRANJAN HIRANANDANI
Co-founder, MD, Hiranandani Group

The layoffs by international tech companies and some Indian start-ups have not helped matters either. They have rendered the workforce even more vulnerable at a time when individuals and enterprises have barely emerged out of two crippling years of the Covid-19 pandemic. Companies are either laying off staff or putting a freeze on hiring (see *System Crash*). Alphabet Inc, Google's parent company, axed 12,000 jobs worldwide, Microsoft said it plans to slash 10,000 jobs this



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

"WE HOPE THE BIG ALLOCATIONS TO VARIOUS GOVERNMENT SCHEMES WILL IMPROVE OUR PROSPECTS"

▲

WAITING FOR A JOB

B.Com. Graduate
Current status:
Informal business

KULDEEP TRIPATHI, 24
Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh

The commerce graduate from Lucknow Christian College sells mobile accessories out of a park bench in the city's Bhopal House Park, hoping to attract custom from the visitors that come to Sharma Tea House nearby. He has already appeared for the Staff Selection exam, but did not succeed. He is now preparing for the state police recruitment board exams. The government's increased focus on multiple sectors this budget has raised his hopes for finding suitable employment.

– Ashish Misra